

Hong Kong Gun Fu

AS WE HAVE seen, novelist and screenwriter William Goldman wrote “nobody knows anything” about the Hollywood of the 1960s and 1970s. Today, we are so much more sophisticated in how we evaluate audience tastes—we have big data and artificial intelligence (AI). We would never make mistakes like passing on *The Princess Bride*.

Just a minute though...

Allow me to tell you about *John Wick*, a 2014 Keanu Reeves movie. The first *John Wick* film was made as an indie film, because none of the major studios were interested in financing it.

It almost wasn't made at all.

Despite being attached to Keanu Reeves, who enjoyed huge box office success with both the *Speed* and *Matrix* franchises, *John Wick* could not find any love from the studios. The film had the stuntmen and fight choreographers from *The Matrix* as directors and writers; despite the insatiable demand for action movies, everyone passed on this shoot-em-up film. *Everyone*.

Danny Boyd, creator of the YouTube channel Cinemastix,^{[28](#)} explains the challenges *John Wick* faced. Quoting Chad Stahelski and David Leitch, the co-directors of the film, who said, “We were literally turned down by every studio that we went to. It's Keanu Reeves being an assassin, kills dozens of people over a puppy, and it's directed by not one but two crazy stuff [*Matrix*] guys.”

Boyd offers more details: “Even after the movie got made, that was far from over. *John Wick* was still a couple of studio execs' beguiled faces away from getting sent straight to Blu-ray. Nobody with any power understood it; nobody with any money wanted to distribute it, and none of the critics in early screenings for it could figure out why they've never heard of it.”